

PHOTO BY PRANIT NITIN GAWAND



under MUDP-3 and 3A for the procurement of rolling stock and setting up maintenance facilities,” say officials. The latter especially provisions for one of the most stringent maintenance requirements drawn up by the railways over the next 35 years for a technology partner. Other than rolling stock, expansion of the existing lines and construction of new corridors will also be undertaken.

A NEW WAY

But will it match the hype? Yes, say officials. The new trains will be air-conditioned with an automatic door-closing system and vestibuled coaches. They will offer uniform seating and efficient LED lighting in coaches, which will also be equipped with large display panels for infotainment and indicators for stations on the exit side. Passenger safety will be ensured through CCTV surveillance and a talk-back system.

The seating arrangement, comprising ergonomically designed

seats, will be the same as the existing electric multiple unit (EMU) trains. A key differentiator will be separate air-conditioned vendor compartments located at either end of the train. “There will be vendor compartments in Vande Bharat local too. However, the luggage compartment will have to be segregated from the air conditioning vents so that the smell of items like fish does not inconvenience commuters,” say officials.

“The decision to procure Vande Bharat rakes reflects the government’s long-term vision for suburban rail networks and reinforces its commitment to providing world-class transportation facilities to commuters,” affirms an excited Subhash Chand Gupta, Chairman and Managing Director of MRVC.

Mumbaikars have longed for an advanced public transport system, say experts. “Introducing upgrades to existing coaches would be a viable option. This could include improvements in seating arrangements, air-conditioning, cleanliness and passenger comfort,” says Jagannarayan Padmanabhan, Senior Director at CRISIL Market Intelligence.

The Vande Bharat local could also address concerns about public transport in Mumbai. “While the current metro being built may not directly compete with the existing [suburban] rail routes, providing a seamless and uniform experience across both modes of transportation is important for passengers,” remarks Padmanabhan.

EASE OF LIVING

It is equally crucial for the railways to assess the post-Covid-19 drop in ridership. From a high of 7.6 million passengers a day in FY20 to 6.1 million in FY23, daily ridership has declined nearly 21 per cent. “By focussing on enhancing the suburban rail network and potentially introducing the Vande Bharat local, the authorities can cater to the growing needs of Mumbai’s residents,” says

FACELIFT



SIZE: The Railway Board has approved procurement of 238 Vande Bharat rakes under Mumbai Urban Transport Project (MUTP)



BUDGET: Acquisition of rakes and expansion of suburban railway network to be done under MUDP-3 (₹10,947 crore) and MUDP-3A (₹33,960 crore) phases



HIGHLIGHTS:

12-car vestibuled trains, fully a/c, automatic doors, uniform seating, LED lighting in the interiors, infotainment panels, digital signage on exits, separate vendor compartments, and CCTV surveillance and talk-back facility for passenger safety

| 25



STRATEGY: Vande Bharat locals to redress the issue of declining ridership by providing a highly reliable world-class travel experience to commuters



LAUNCH: Timelines to be defined in tender documents that are currently being prepared

Source: MRVC, BT Research